GEOGRAPHY IN HISTORY

3.4 Economic Activities in the Thirteen Colonies

MAIN IDEA Colonists used the abundant resources around them to develop thriving economies in three colonial regions.

SHAPING THE COLONIAL ECONOMY

When European settlers came to North America, they took advantage of the region's **natural resources**. Natural resources are divided into two categories: living and nonliving. The earth provides living resources, such as plants, trees, and animals, that help feed, shelter, and clothe humans. The earth also provides nonliving resources, such as minerals, water, and soil. Both living and nonliving natural resources provide **raw materials**, or substances used to make products.

People use natural resources to engage in **economic activities**, or the production, distribution, and consumption of goods and services. When you go to the store to buy groceries, you are engaging in an economic activity.

How are natural resources, raw materials, and economic activities related? Consider this example. Colonists in New England chopped down trees in the region's thick forests for timber, or wood used for building. Timber became one of New England's most important raw materials. Shipbuilding became one of its most important economic activities.

The natural resources and raw materials available in different regions shaped how the colonies developed. Some natural resources, raw materials, and economic activities were unique to one region, but others were common among all three.



Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.

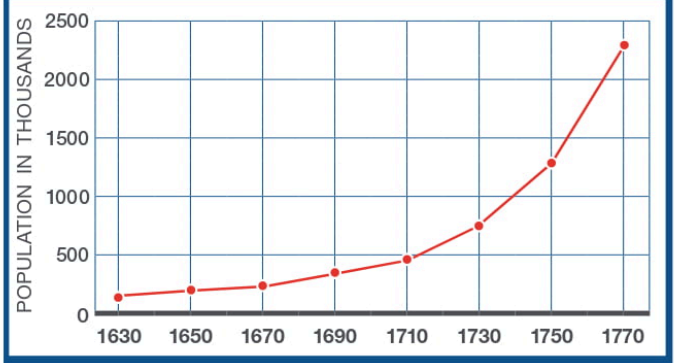


COLONIAL TRADE

The American colonies exported raw materials and agricultural products such as timber and tobacco to Europe. In exchange, they imported manufactured goods from Europe.

	CLIMATE	PHYSICAL FEATURES	RAW MATERIALS	ECONOMIC ACTIVITIES
NEW ENGLAND COLONIES				
MASSACHUSETTS	mild, short summers; long, cold winters	mountains, forests, rivers, poor soil	fish, whales, timber, cattle, wheat	farming, fishing, shipbuilding, rum production
CONNECTICUT	mild, short summers; long, cold winters	mountains, rivers, and poor, rocky soil	cattle, iron	shipbuilding, rum production
MIDDLE COLONIES				
NEW YORK	humid summers; cold, snowy winters	mountains, plains, hills, rivers	furs, timber, cattle, wheat	trade and shipping, shipbuilding, farming
PENNSYLVANIA	mild summers; mild winters	mountains, plains, fertile soil, rivers	flax, wheat, sheep, cattle, pigs	farming, shipbuilding
SOUTHERN COLONIES				
VIRGINIA	warm, humid; plentiful rainfall	rich soil, rivers, coastal lowlands	furs, cattle, pigs, wheat, corn, tobacco, fish	farming, fishing, rum production
NORTH CAROLINA	warm, humid; plentiful rainfall	deep forests, rivers, grasslands	indigo, tobacco, furs, timber, pigs, cattle, rice, corn	farming

Colonial Population Growth, 1630–1770



As the colonies developed their economic activities, people migrated to North America in search of economic opportunities, and the population grew dramatically.

Source: from *The Population of the United States* by Douglas L. Anderton, Richard E. Barrett, and Donald J. Bogue, 1997

THINK LIKE A GEOGRAPHER

1. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** For each colonial region, identify an example of a natural resource that helped the region develop a specific economic activity.
2. **INTERPRET CHARTS** In what ways are the raw materials and economic activities of the New England Colonies and the Southern Colonies alike and different?
3. **ANALYZE ENVIRONMENTAL CONCEPTS** In what ways did the quality and quantity of natural resources impact population growth in the 13 colonies?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.